

Chapter 35 Part 1

The conference room seemed to be put on pause.

Zhou Yi'an was wearing a well-tailored black suit, with white shirt showing at the sleeves and collar. Particularly noticeable were her shirt's gold cufflinks and the expensive brand-name watch on her wrist. Her voice had a sandy quality, becoming a husky voice when she lowered it.

The entire design, combined with her bold and confident smile, instantly mesmerized everyone.

They seemed unable to believe that RT's annual emerging designer¹ would have such a face.

She said very little, just curled her lips into a smile at everyone: "Please take care of me from now on."

A few seconds later, it was Lumi, who never let the atmosphere turn cold, who was the first to applaud. She clapped super hard, and the entire conference room could hear her "clap clap clap" sounds.

Sally followed suit, even saying in her not-so-standard Chinese: "Beautiful!"

This made Cherry glance at her.

The department manager asked Zhou Yi'an to take a seat, and then the weekly meeting would begin.

The assistant responsible for arranging seating didn't know a new person was coming, so there was no seat for Zhou Yi'an. But Zhou Yi'an showed no shyness at all, moving a chair and sitting directly beside Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu immediately closed her laptop and entered a state of full alert.

No matter how imaginative she was, she couldn't have imagined that the new designer would be Zhou Yi'an.

Sally was quite enthusiastic, calling Zhou Yi'an over: "Beauty, sit here!"

Lin Luoxi, who was originally sitting beside her, rolled her eyes, stood up and walked to Zhou Yi'an's side, saying in an unfriendly tone: "Change seats."

"I'd rather not." Zhou Yi'an crossed her legs, casually picked up a pen from the conference table, twirling it between her fingers, still wearing that mischievous smile. "I prefer sitting next to the pretty sister."

Xu Qingzhu frowned slightly, glancing at her thoughtfully: "Miss Zhou."

Zhou Yi'an looked over with a smile, her voice rising at the end, as if flirting: "Hmm?"

Xu Qingzhu hugged her laptop and stood up, showing a proper smile: "If I remember correctly, you and my wife are the same age, so I'm younger than you. Sorry."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

Someone with a low sense of humor couldn't help but laugh out loud.

The conference room suddenly became extremely awkward.

Zhou Yi'an didn't seem to notice, her smile undiminished, the corners of her mouth curving up even higher: "That was indeed presumptuous of me. Miss Xu has a good memory."

"Not bad." Xu Qingzhu replied coolly.

Anyone could see that the new designer had history with the young miss, but what kind of history exactly, no one was clear about.

So everyone in the conference room perked up their ears, afraid of missing any moment.

But Xu Qingzhu didn't want to discuss private matters at the company. She just coldly reminded everyone: "Let's start the meeting."

"Gu Yining, distribute the materials to everyone." Xu Qingzhu connected her laptop to the projector. "Let's first discuss the autumn new product launch event."

Originally everyone thought there would be a good show in the conference room, but Xu Qingzhu started talking about work.

The meeting proceeded in an orderly manner as usual.

Zhou Yi'an also didn't do anything overly outrageous, except that her gaze kept staring intently at Xu Qingzhu.

And Xu Qingzhu acted like nothing was happening, ignoring her gaze.

Footnotes:

1. **RT annual emerging designer:** RT appears to be a prestigious design award or organization in this fictional world, similar to real-world design competitions and recognition programs.

Chapter 35 Part 2

The meeting lasted nearly an hour. Xu Qingzhu announced adjournment and told everyone to return to their respective positions to get busy. Everyone left the conference room one after another.

The department manager was eager to play matchmaker between Zhou Yi'an and Xu Qingzhu, leading Zhou Yi'an in front of Xu Qingzhu. "Since everyone was here earlier, I didn't introduce you properly. Let me formally introduce you now. This is our design department's deputy manager, also our Director Xu's daughter, Miss Xu Qingzhu. She graduated from Qingyi University¹ with a finance major, took an additional two years of MBA, and although she just graduated, she's very capable - you should have witnessed that earlier. And this is our new employee that Director Xu spent great effort to recruit, RT's annual emerging designer, Miss Zhou Yi'an."

Xu Qingzhu was organizing the documents on the table. Upon hearing this, she looked up and glanced over, seeing the department manager grinning like "a landlord's foolish son,"² completely oblivious to what was happening.

She sighed helplessly and extended her hand slightly. "Hello, Xu Qingzhu."

"Hello." Zhou Yi'an smiled. "It's not our first meeting. Why are you being so polite, Miss Xu?"

"You two know each other?" The department manager was surprised.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She really seriously doubted how someone with his intelligence managed to reach the department manager position.

He had even been in the marketing department before coming to the design department.

It could only be said that Minghui Jewelry's internal staff were all such "talents" - it would be hard not to go bankrupt.

Zhou Yi'an: "Of course."

Xu Qingzhu: "We've met once."

Both voices rang out simultaneously in the conference room. The department manager paused slightly. "So do you know each other or not?"

Xu Qingzhu frowned and couldn't help but retort, "Does it concern you?"

Her tone was relatively calm, but because she had a lot on her mind, it didn't sound particularly friendly.

"Department manager," Xu Qingzhu said, "Can we only discuss business matters in the company? Whether we have private relations or not isn't important."

The department manager was taken aback. This was the first time he'd seen Xu Qingzhu lose her temper, and he quickly said "okay" several times.

Xu Qingzhu walked toward the door. Zhou Yi'an took her hands out of her pants pockets and patted the department manager's shoulder, her tone teasing and mocking: "Department manager, you're a department manager after all. How could you just... emmm"

She didn't finish her sentence, just carried a smile that seemed meaningful.

Zhou Yi'an hadn't intended to avoid Xu Qingzhu hearing, so her voice wasn't quiet, and Xu Qingzhu heard it perfectly.

Upon hearing this, Xu Qingzhu stopped walking and turned back to look at Zhou Yi'an. "Miss Zhou, since you've joined Minghui Jewelry, you're an employee of Minghui Jewelry. Starting to provoke leadership relationships on your first day - is this because you're arrogant about your talents or do you want to be fired? Our design department is small and can't tolerate two-faced new employees. If you have other ideas, I can help you process your resignation."

"Ah? I'd be fine with that, but it depends on whether your father agrees." Zhou Yi'an shrugged indifferently. "No matter how capable a princess is, she still has to consider the emperor's wishes, right?"

After saying this, she frowned slightly, but her smile grew even brighter as she said without much apology: "Sorry, I'm just making an analogy. I didn't mean it that way."

"Well, I didn't know that Mr. Zhou would actually agree to let you come out to work." Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue, her voice cold and clear, her expression disdainful. "I thought princesses could only be kept at home."

She directly used Zhou Yi'an's words against her.

"Miss Zhou," Xu Qingzhu said, "If you're here to be a designer, then Minghui Jewelry welcomes you. If you're just here to play office palace intrigue, then sorry, we don't have the time or energy to play with you. You yourself are a high and mighty young lady who doesn't worry about food or clothing and doesn't know the hardships of common people, but the employees here all depend on this job to support their families. They have elderly parents and young children to care for - they're different from you."

She paused briefly, gently pressing her lips together, her voice becoming deeper. "The day Minghui Jewelry goes bankrupt, I'll send all the materials to Mr. Zhou. Not only that, all media will broadcast it together, including that day's recordings. You'll go from being an idle young miss to the executioner who caused a company's bankruptcy."

Zhou Yi'an's smile disappeared. "You!"

Xu Qingzhu said: "If Minghui Jewelry goes bankrupt, then I have nothing left to lose either. And that day's recordings can prove that you had the motive to do such a thing. Even if it was originally the already shaky Minghui Jewelry, as long as you joined, if this company goes bankrupt, it will definitely be related to you. Mr. Zhou has come this far and surely has quite a few enemies. Tell me, even if I let you go, will others let you go?"

Only five people remained in the large conference room.

Xu Qingzhu, the department manager, Zhou Yi'an, and Cherry and Sally.

Sally was completely confused, constantly tugging at Cherry's clothes asking what Xu Qingzhu was saying and whether they were fighting.

Cherry's mind worked quickly. Although her family couldn't compare to the Liang family, she had some connections to understand insider circle matters, and moreover - Zhou Yi'an.

Surnamed Zhou, how many people in all of Haichuan City³ could have the surname Zhou?

She naturally understood Zhou Yi'an's identity.

But she had no time to answer Sally's questions.

She was too busy enjoying the drama herself - how could she have time for her?

The department manager was completely confused: Where am I? What are they talking about? Why can't I understand? Minghui Company is going bankrupt? Why would it go bankrupt? Isn't it doing quite well now?

Department manager: ...Why is even the young miss's arguing so extraordinary?

Xu Qingzhu's words dropped a bombshell in Zhou Yi'an's heart.

She immediately frowned tightly.

"What do you say, Miss Zhou?" Xu Qingzhu asked calmly.

She was like a bamboo standing alone in the world⁴ - seemingly swaying in wind and rain, appearing to be on the verge of collapse, yet retaining a thread of vitality.

And this vitality was like sparks in spring - needing only to fall into wild grass to spread like wildfire in an instant.

Just like the current Minghui Jewelry.

Xu Qingzhu's tone was slow, and she didn't use her home field advantage to suppress Zhou Yi'an, nor did she show any fear.

She stated her viewpoint neither humbly nor arrogantly, while also elevating Zhou Yi'an and threatening her at the same time, bringing out the two great weapons of Zhou's father and the media to make Zhou Yi'an feel fearful.

Zhou Yi'an thought for a long time, then slowly walked over, getting extremely close to her.

Xu Qingzhu didn't like the smell on her - a heavy cigarette smell that was very choking.

Xu Qingzhu stepped back half a step.

Zhou Yi'an curved her lips into a light smile, smiling quite wickedly. "I think Miss Xu makes a lot of sense."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes were clear and transparent, yet also like unfathomable ocean depths, making it impossible to guess what she was thinking. Just looking over calmly was enough to make people feel pressure.

Zhou Yi'an didn't back down either. She reached out and gently dusted off some non-existent dust from Xu Qingzhu's shoulder, leaning close and lowering her voice: "Little cutie, why are you so hostile toward me?"

Xu Qingzhu stepped back one step, her brow furrowing like a small mountain.

"You're so beautiful, why is your heart so malicious?" Zhou Yi'an continued. "Can't I simply be here to find a job? After all, I graduated from a first-class foreign university's design department and have rich work experience."

"I worked at ME⁵ for a year and a half, and won RT's annual emerging designer award last year. Coming to work at your Minghui Jewelry, my qualifications are more than sufficient. Why can't you think that I'm here for charity work? Helping your company get out of trouble and return to its peak, to prove my abilities." At this point, Zhou Yi'an smiled lightly. "After all, Minghui Jewelry was once a legend in Haichuan City."

Xu Qingzhu's face clearly showed two words - disbelief.

She still had a lot of work to do later and was too lazy to argue with Zhou Yi'an here. She helped push Zhou Yi'an back to create distance between them, her voice becoming increasingly cold: "I hope Miss Zhou will do as she says."

Zhou Yi'an: "...?"

That's it?

She was still waiting for Xu Qingzhu to retort.

But Xu Qingzhu said: "I hope Designer Zhou's arrival will bring our Minghui Jewelry back from the dead."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

Footnotes:

1. **Qingyi University (青翼大學):** A fictional prestigious university in this story's setting.
2. **"Landlord's foolish son" (地主家的傻兒子):** A Chinese idiom referring to someone from a wealthy family who appears simple-minded or naive, often used to describe someone who seems oblivious to social situations.
3. **Haichuan City (海舟市):** The fictional city where this story takes place, literally meaning "Sea Boat City."
4. **"Like a bamboo standing alone in the world" (遺世獨立的竹子):** This metaphor draws on bamboo's cultural significance in Chinese literature as a symbol of resilience, integrity, and grace under pressure.
5. **ME:** Appears to be a prestigious international design company in this fictional world.

Chapter 35 Part 3

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Lunchtime.

Sally's gossiping soul was completely unstoppable. She ran to Xu Qingzhu's office and asked again and again.

Xu Qingzhu sighed helplessly: "Cherry, manage her."

Lin Luoxi scoffed lightly: "Can't manage her. She's a wild horse that's broken free of its reins."

Afterward, Xu Qingzhu was bothered to the point where she had no choice but to briefly tell Sally about the grudges between herself and Zhou Yi'an.

After listening, Sally summarized only one point: Zhou Yi'an was Xu Qingzhu's romantic rival.

"OMG. You and Liang Shi are already married, yet the mistress still won't give up! Did she find no breakthrough with Liang Shi, so she came to cause trouble for you?" Sally crossed her arms, anxious like an ant on a hot pan. "The mistress has come right to your doorstep, and you're still this calm? Blanche! Put down those documents!"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She rubbed her forehead helplessly. "What's mine can't be taken away, what's not mine can't be kept."

Sally: "..."

She poked Lin Luoxi: "What does that mean?"

Lin Luoxi was eating, stuck her chopsticks into her rice, and explained viciously in English: "It means even if you wanted to leave back then, I could tie steel bars to your legs and you'd still be able to walk away."

Sally: "..."

Sally shrank her neck, not daring to provoke Lin Luoxi further, and continued talking to Xu Qingzhu: "Blanche, this calls for war."

"What war?" Xu Qingzhu said. "I checked the information. Zhou Yi'an is indeed RT's annual emerging designer, and during her year at ME¹, two of ME's hit products were designed by her."

"Is Mr. Zhou..." Lin Luoxi pointed at the ceiling, speaking vaguely: "That one?"

"Yes." Xu Qingzhu smiled bitterly. "How many Mr. Zhous are there in all of Haichuan City?"

However, fortunately, Mr. Zhou wasn't completely muddle-headed either.

Even if he doted on Zhou Yi'an, there were limits.

She heard that after the last banquet, Zhou Yi'an was confined.

And Mr. Zhou was very angry, directly freezing her cards. No matter how much Mrs. Zhou pleaded, it was useless.

"Then according to this, she's completely untouchable." Lin Luoxi was worried. "You and Liang Shi won't really get divorced because of her, will you?"

Xu Qingzhu was silent for a few seconds, then said very seriously: "Even if Liang Shi and I divorce someday, it won't be because of Zhou Yi'an."

Their divorce was already a foregone conclusion anyway.

Sally, as a desperate gossip-eating creature, couldn't get her fill due to the language barrier and was extremely anxious.

She began to regret: "I should have studied more Chinese when I was in school."

Lin Luoxi scoffed: "You've been in China for four years and your Chinese level is still this garbage. If Chinese had proficiency tests, you probably couldn't even pass level two."

Sally: "It's because Chinese is too difficult! Pinyin² is too hard to learn."

Sally and Lin Luoxi began their daily bickering.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu buried her head in signing documents, then took time to send her father a message, asking if he was at the company and wanting to meet with him.

She needed to figure out why Zhou Yi'an came to Minghui.

"Blanche," Sally said to Xu Qingzhu after she and Lin Luoxi had called a truce. "From now on, don't let Liang Shi drive you to the company, and don't let her pick you up either. Otherwise, it'll create opportunities for her and the mistress to meet. This is called..."

She racked her brains to think of an idiom: "Nurturing a tiger to invite disaster."³

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Got it."

However—

"Sally, don't use such terms in the company from now on, and don't bring private matters to work." Xu Qingzhu said. "The company is the company. If Zhou Yi'an really has talent, then I will definitely make the best use of her abilities. I don't want my personal affairs to affect the company's development."

Especially now that the company was already struggling.

If Zhou Yi'an's arrival could change the current predicament, she wouldn't mind either.

She only started eating after finishing the documents, but halfway through her meal, she received a reply from Xu Guangyao saying he was there and she could come over anytime.

Xu Qingzhu casually ate a few more bites, then greeted Lin Luoxi and hurriedly left the office.

While going upstairs, she even encountered Zhou Yi'an.

Zhou Yi'an was holding an iced Americano⁴ and nodded to Xu Qingzhu with a teasing tone: "Little cutie, where are you going?"

Xu Qingzhu frowned: "It's none of your business."

The elevator door opened. Before stepping into the elevator, Xu Qingzhu stopped and said very seriously: "Don't call me by that kind of name."

Zhou Yi'an: "What kind?"

She thought Xu Qingzhu would fall for it, but Xu Qingzhu said expressionlessly: "The kind you just used."

She said: "I'm afraid I'll throw up even last night's midnight snack."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Then I'm truly sorry." Zhou Yi'an raised an eyebrow. "I thought you were also someone with... romantic flair."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled, like a spring breeze, then restrained her smile, her voice much gentler than before.

Zhou Yi'an was puzzled: "Is it that funny?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "Sorry, I'm not laughing at you."

A smile appeared on her face, which perfectly blended bright beauty and pure innocence. "I just thought of my wife. I'm not someone without romantic flair either."

When mentioning Liang Shi, Zhou Yi'an's smile immediately disappeared completely.

Her level was still relatively low - she couldn't yet achieve the composure of remaining unmoved even if Mount Tai collapsed before her.

Xu Qingzhu continued: "But I usually only have romantic flair with my wife, like calling her 'darling wife.'"

When saying those last four words, Xu Qingzhu's voice rose at the end, sounding particularly intimate and tinged with some ambiguity.

Especially when spoken in her slightly cold voice, it made people's thoughts wander and imagination run wild.

Zhou Yi'an's iced Americano cup was somewhat deformed in her grip.

Xu Qingzhu's smile didn't diminish, her voice still gentle: "Our romantic flair is never displayed outside, especially not in a place like the company. Even if my wife were standing here, I wouldn't play such romantic games with her. Moreover, I think romantic flair should only be played with someone you love to be meaningful. What do you think, Miss Zhou?"

Zhou Yi'an: "You!"

She said one word through gritted teeth before being interrupted by Xu Qingzhu: "Otherwise it easily becomes workplace sexual harassment."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"I'll go first." Xu Qingzhu said. "Designer Zhou, work hard."

Zhou Yi'an finally couldn't hold back: "Xu Qingzhu, you really are sharp-tongued."

The elevator door slowly closed, and Xu Qingzhu maintained a faint smile throughout.

Zhou Yi'an was so angry her face was almost distorted.

Damn it!

F*ck.

Zhou Yi'an stood there, her mind filled with nothing but curse words.

This was clearly showing off to her!

"Wife" this, "wife" that - hah.

She hadn't seen them being so lovey-dovey before, but now they were putting on an act, weren't they?

But it was still because Liang Shi was too partial to her.

The favored naturally acted without restraint.

The elevator opened again, and a group of new colleagues who had just finished eating outside saw the new designer with an expression like she'd eaten sh*t.

Someone boldly tried to make conversation: "Designer Zhou, have you eaten?"

Only then did Zhou Yi'an come back to her senses. Without thinking, she answered angrily: "Eat sh*t!"

Then she grabbed her iced Americano and returned to her workstation.

Leaving everyone standing there in confusion: "..."

So the new designer had such unique tastes.

Footnotes:

1. **ME:** A prestigious international design company mentioned in previous chapters.
2. **Pinyin (拼音):** The official romanization system for Standard Chinese, used to teach pronunciation of Chinese characters.
3. **"Nurturing a tiger to invite disaster" (養虎為患):** A Chinese idiom meaning to shelter a potential threat that will eventually cause harm.
4. **Iced Americano:** A popular coffee drink, showing Zhou Yi'an's westernized tastes.

Chapter 35 Part 4

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Xu Qingzhu went unimpeded all the way to the CEO's office.

In the office, Xu Guangyao was brewing a pot of tea while looking over marketing proposals submitted by the marketing department. Seeing that it was Xu Qingzhu who entered, he just frowned slightly before lowering his head to look at documents again.

Xu Qingzhu didn't react much either. The lunch break was short, so she walked to the desk and asked directly: "Do you know who Zhou Yi'an is?"

Xu Guangyao looked up at his daughter, who had already become adept at navigating the workplace despite just entering it, and answered: "I know."

"Dad." Xu Qingzhu called to him. "I know what you're thinking. Now all the celebrities in the circle want to curry favor with Mr. Zhou, so Zhou Yi'an has become the target of everyone's flattery. But even if a pie falls from heaven, don't you check what filling it has? Not every pie can be eaten."

Xu Guangyao poured her a cup of tea, his tone gentle and calm: "Sit."

Xu Qingzhu sat across from him. She didn't drink the tea, just continued: "Dad, haven't you thought about why Zhou Yi'an wants to come to Minghui? With her status and qualifications, there are plenty of big companies that want her. Why would she come to Minghui?!"

"That would have to be asked of Zhou Yi'an." Xu Guangyao suddenly frowned. "Did you just come here to interrogate me?"

Xu Qingzhu took a deep breath: "No, I just came to ask you why you recruited Zhou Yi'an. Our temple is small¹ and can't accommodate such a big Buddha."

"If we can accommodate even you, how can we not accommodate her?" Xu Guangyao said. "It was just that I encountered Miss Zhou by chance at the banquet that day and learned that Miss Zhou was a top student from a prestigious foreign university's design department. She had just returned to the country not long ago and wanted to find a jewelry company for internship. Her understanding was still of the Minghui Jewelry from many years ago. What's wrong with wanting to work at Minghui?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She first ignored her father's earlier sarcastic words about her, focusing only on his latter statement: "Dad, as the daughter of the Zhou family, and having worked in this industry for several years, how could she not know Minghui's current situation? Why can you be so naïve..."

Halfway through her words, Xu Guangyao's expression had already changed.

Xu Qingzhu picked up the water cup and drank the tea in one gulp, swallowing all her words back.

That word "naive" ultimately wasn't spoken.

Only after calming down did she continue: "Did Zhou Yi'an approach you proactively?"

"Yes." Xu Guangyao said. "We met by chance at the banquet. She said she hadn't found work yet, so I extended an olive branch to her. RT's annual emerging designer - just this title alone is enough. If our autumn new product launch has her work, won't we be able to make a sensation?"

At this point, Xu Guangyao's eyes and brows were tinged with smugness. "Those two people you brought in - I looked at their work. Isn't it all just superficial? Young people nowadays won't like it."

"Who says so?" Xu Qingzhu said. "Those are clearly very innovative designs. I don't care - the flagship item for the autumn collection must be Lin Luoxi's work. I swallowed my pride to ask her to come, and she stayed up all night rushing to complete so many drafts. If you want to replace her work at this critical moment, then I..."

The words "won't do it anymore" got stuck in her throat.

She couldn't say them no matter what.

She couldn't possibly not do it.

Once she stopped, it would push Minghui into the abyss, and it would go bankrupt sooner or later.

But Xu Guangyao picked up on her unfinished words: "Won't do it anymore, right? Then resign. Regardless of how Lin Luoxi's design is, as long as we use Miss Zhou's reputation, there will definitely be media and celebrities buying it. Our marketing will definitely occupy an advantageous position. Plus those socialites - to curry favor with Mr. Zhou, they'll have to give our products some face. For this autumn collection, the flagship item must be Miss Zhou's design."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She knew this was what her father was planning!

Short-sighted!

During her time at the company, she had roughly figured out why the company was gradually declining.

Nepotism - most of the company's employees had some kind of family connections. Take the design department manager, for example. He was some shareholder's nephew who couldn't find work after graduation, so he was arranged into Minghui Jewelry's marketing department. Later, when Qin Sisi resigned, this incompetent guy was directly transferred to the design department.

Other departments had this phenomenon to some extent as well.

Xu Qingzhu wanted to carry out sweeping reforms, but now she had to focus on the autumn new product launch first. Only if this went well could she have a voice in the company and save Minghui Jewelry's reputation.

Moreover, Xu Guangyao focused too much on marketing, probably related to the regrets left from when he was a designer.

Originally, as a designer, he thought his work was good but never got opportunities. Those who got opportunities were all works that used high concepts and good marketing. So after becoming chairman of Minghui Jewelry, he had always focused on marketing. He firmly believed that good marketing was like a pig standing at the wind outlet² - no matter how heavy, it could still fly.

After all these years, even though Minghui Jewelry declined year by year, he still firmly believed his theory was correct.

"Dad, I've told you before - for all companies that produce content, content is king." Xu Qingzhu said. "We do need marketing to let the public know about our products, but back then our marketing was already sufficient. Almost everyone knew Minghui. For new companies, marketing is very important, but for established jewelry companies like us, content is the way. Only by ensuring our product styles and quality don't decline can we maintain old customers and have good reputation, which will naturally attract new customers. But you're putting the cart before the horse now!"

"Are you teaching me how to do business?" Xu Guangyao asked in a deep voice.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and said nothing.

The atmosphere between father and daughter became tense for a moment.

Xu Qingzhu stubbornly held her ground, refusing to give in no matter what.

After a long while, Xu Guangyao was the first to break the silence: "Qingzhu, everything Dad does is for the good of this family. Your health has never been good, and working so hard at the company will exhaust your body.

"I heard from Zhang Qiyi that you worked overtime for five consecutive days last week. How can your body handle this if it continues? Dad doesn't want you to come to the company because he doesn't want you to worry. Why do you have to oppose me? You've already married into the Liang family anyway. Dad will solve all the problems. Just don't ask the Liang family for money anymore. Get along well with Liang Shi - she loves you so much, she won't let you suffer."

Zhang Qiyi was their design department manager.

"If I don't come in, Minghui will go bankrupt and liquidate!" Xu Qingzhu suddenly shouted.

Despite all the hardship and exhaustion these days, she hadn't said a single word of complaint. She just wanted to do everything possible to preserve her grandfather's legacy business.

But what about her father?

Her father wanted her to mind her own business.

And he wanted to rely on someone with an unpredictable temperament.

She clearly wanted to help, but it had turned into opposition.

All the grievances accumulated over these days exploded in an instant. Her shouting stunned Xu Guangyao, but after a moment he replied: "I've been running this for so many years, and Minghui hasn't gone bankrupt! I've still maintained the family well. You went to a private school, and I never let you suffer any grievances."

"But four months ago, if it weren't for the money Liang Shi brought, Minghui would have already gone bankrupt." Xu Qingzhu said. "Even the villa we live in would have had to be mortgaged to the bank."

"That was money Liang Shi gave voluntarily!" Xu Guangyao still refused to admit that it was his management mistakes that led Minghui to such a predicament.

"But why did Liang Shi give it? Can't you use your brain? Or are you just weaving illusions for yourself - as long as Minghui hasn't collapsed yet, you can still live in your utopia!" Xu Qingzhu suppressed her choking voice. "This matter is the same. Why Zhou Yi'an came - don't you really know? She came because of me! To oppose me! Last time at the banquet, I slapped her, so she's coming to cause trouble for me. Now that I've said this, do you understand? Or are you planning to continue pretending not to understand, continue making decisions with your eyes closed, regardless of Minghui's fate?"

Xu Guangyao was made to feel almost ashamed by her words, but still maintained his last shred of dignity, picking apart her words to ask: "Why did you slap her?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She suddenly felt that everything she had just said was like playing music to a cow.³

In her father's eyes, there were only two types of people: those who could be used, and those who couldn't.

Zhou Yi'an was someone who could be used.

He wouldn't think about this being a knife that could stab back at any time.

To him, this was the last straw to grasp.

"Dad." Xu Qingzhu sighed. "There's no point in discussing this now. I just want to ask you - everything in the design department is for me to decide, right?"

"Make Miss Zhou's work the flagship item." Xu Guangyao said.

Xu Qingzhu: "...I absolutely will not compromise on this matter."

Xu Qingzhu knew she couldn't persuade him, so she simply switched to a tough approach: "I also absolutely will not leave Minghui. No matter how tired I get, I will protect this family business."

"You could live a good leisurely life, why do you insist on pushing yourself like this?" Xu Guangyao was annoyed. "Is Liang Shi not treating you well? I'll go find her! She promised to treat my daughter well when you got married! How long has it been since the wedding and she's already changed!"

"It has nothing to do with Liang Shi." Xu Qingzhu stopped him, taking a deep breath. "Dad, I've studied for so many years. I can't just stay home being a full-time housewife. I need to work."

"Then find yourself an easy job. Let Liang Shi arrange something for you at their family company. You don't need to worry about Minghui's affairs." Xu Guangyao said. "I'll handle it."

"But your way of handling it is just procrastination." Xu Qingzhu said. "Delaying day by day until Minghui goes bankrupt and liquidates. This company can't withstand your kind of turmoil."

Xu Guangyao: "..."

Xu Qingzhu said in a deep voice: "I don't need to rely on anyone to get opportunities, and I don't need easy work. If you really care about me, don't stop me from doing these things. Regarding Zhou Yi'an, don't make any deals with her behind my back. That will only make me more passive and make things harder for me."

Footnotes:

1. **"Our temple is small" (咱們家廟小):** A Chinese idiom meaning the organization/place is too small to accommodate someone of high status or ability.
2. **"A pig standing at the wind outlet" (站在風口上的豬):** A popular Chinese business metaphor meaning that with the right timing and favorable conditions, even the most unlikely ventures can succeed.
3. **"Playing music to a cow" (對牛彈琴):** A Chinese idiom meaning to speak to someone who cannot understand or appreciate what you're saying.

Chapter 35 Part 5

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Xu Qingzhu deflated in the elevator.

The moment the door closed, she leaned against the corner and took several deep breaths.

To be honest, her mind was actually completely blank.

She hadn't known that her father had always held such thoughts, hoping she would marry Liang Shi and become a full-time housewife.

Of course, there were still quite a few Omegas in this society who relied on Alphas for support, but most worked together as a couple.

In socialite circles, most were Omega wives who didn't go to work.

But Xu Qingzhu didn't want to become that kind of person.

After arguing with Xu Guangyao, her mood was very low, but after returning to the office, she had to force herself to cheer up and work.

Until Lin Luoxi came to find her.

Xu Qingzhu asked: "What's wrong?"

"Are you okay?" Lin Luoxi handed her a cup of brown sugar water¹. "You look very weak."

"I'm fine." Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly, afraid they would worry. "Nothing serious. Have you talked with the marketing department?"

"There's a small problem." Lin Luoxi hesitated but still said: "Now I hear that the higher-ups want to use Zhou Yi'an's design drafts as the flagship items. All our previous plans have become alternatives, including Sally's carefully designed 'Starry Night.'"

"It won't happen." Xu Qingzhu was already mentally prepared for this matter and temporarily reassured Lin Luoxi. "Just continue doing your work well. I guarantee that for this new product launch, your autumn series will definitely be the flagship items. And Sally too - tell her to relax. I won't let her return from America for nothing. If I brought you here just to make you suffer grievances, then what kind of person would I be?"

Lin Luoxi was just worried about her: "Actually, I came just to tell you that Sally and I are here to help, so whether our works are used as flagship items or not doesn't matter. The main thing is Zhou Yi'an's design drafts - although they look pretty good, the style is too dark and doesn't match Minghui's usual concept."

"I understand." Xu Qingzhu smiled strongly. "Thank you, Luoxi."

"No problem." Lin Luoxi said. "Rest up. I just came to tell you."

After Lin Luoxi left, Xu Qingzhu stood at the door and called Zhou Yi'an, asking her to come in for a meeting and to bring her design drafts.

As Lin Luoxi had said, Zhou Yi'an's design talent was indeed high, worthy of her prestigious university graduate status, but the style didn't match Minghui. It absolutely couldn't be used as the flagship item for the new product launch, and couldn't even be brought onto the new product launch stage.

She directly rejected all of Zhou Yi'an's drafts.

Zhou Yi'an asked her: "You have a problem with me, don't you?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "No. Quite the opposite - since you've joined Minghui, I hope to discover the value in you, but this set really can't be used."

Zhou Yi'an scoffed: "Do you understand design? An MBA graduate - why are you interfering in the design field?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't take her contemptuous attitude to heart, but smiled: "My family has been in this business for generations, so do you think I understand? All the accessories I've worn since childhood have been Minghui's. In this area, you really don't have the right to question me."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"If you don't want to use it, then forget it." Zhou Yi'an picked up her design drafts and was about to leave. "I didn't beg you to use them anyway."

"But I think your design talent is pretty good." Xu Qingzhu said. "So you could consider designing a set that fits our concept."

"When a work is given a specific concept, it loses its soul." Zhou Yi'an said. "I don't want themed design."

Xu Qingzhu: "So you can't do it?"

Zhou Yi'an: "...Are you provoking me?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "Not at all. I'm just stating facts. I thought RT's annual emerging designer had such great abilities, but it turns out you can only do your own things. Then what's the point of you joining the company?"

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She said impatiently: "Mind your own business? I'll join wherever I want."

"Indeed, it's not my business to manage. After all, Miss Zhou has special privileges - she can join wherever she wants." Xu Qingzhu still maintained that bland tone.

Zhou Yi'an: "...Xu Qingzhu, stop being so passive-aggressive. I got in through my abilities. What special privileges did I use?"

"Well, I wouldn't know." Xu Qingzhu said. "As the design department's deputy manager, I haven't seen your abilities. Designers who can't create works even when given a theme - we generally call them third-rate designers."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Fuck." Zhou Yi'an cursed under her breath. "You're the third-rate one. When I was winning awards in international design competitions, you probably didn't even know where you were playing in the mud."

"Then let me see your abilities." Xu Qingzhu said. "Preferably use your work to slap my face hard and make me regret saying these words today."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She was silent for a few seconds, then said through gritted teeth: "What theme?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled and casually threw out two words: "Autumn."

Zhou Yi'an said viciously: "Fine! You just wait!"

Then she slammed Xu Qingzhu's office door without mercy.

Xu Qingzhu leaned back in her chair and exhaled. Sally and Cherry, who had been standing at the door listening to the drama, and Cherry who had returned to hear the complete scene, walked in, both shocked.

After a long while, Cherry said with inner excitement but maintaining composure: "Squeezing every bit of value out of your romantic rival - amazing."

"Blanche, I misunderstood you." Sally sighed. "You're the real master of passive aggression²."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

For a moment, she couldn't tell whether these two were praising or criticizing her.

But Minghui's current situation had indeed pushed her to desperation, so she couldn't even spare Zhou Yi'an.

She just smiled: "Sometimes, garbage is just resources placed in the wrong location."

After hearing this, Sally and Cherry gave her thumbs up: "Worthy of you indeed."

Meanwhile, Zhou Yi'an, who had left the office and returned to her workstation, held the stack of design drafts in her hands, feeling that something was off but unable to say exactly what.

A colleague gossiped and asked her: "What did the young miss want with you?"

Zhou Yi'an expressionlessly threw the stack of design drafts into the trash can: "Changing drafts."

"You got your drafts rejected?" the colleague asked. "Do you still have design drafts to compete for the new product launch?"

"Redraw." Zhou Yi'an said.

Colleague: "..."

The colleague showed a sympathetic expression.

A few seconds later, Zhou Yi'an suddenly threw down the pen she had just used to draw a few lines and cursed under her breath: "Damn."

Had she been played by Xu Qingzhu?

How interesting indeed.

Footnotes:

1. **Brown sugar water (紅糖水):** A traditional Chinese remedy believed to help with fatigue, menstrual discomfort, and general weakness, especially for women.
2. **Master of passive aggression (陰陽家):** Sally uses this term playfully. In Chinese culture, "陰陽" (yin-yang) can refer to being indirect or using subtle sarcasm, which Sally interprets as Xu Qingzhu's skillful use of psychological tactics.

Chapter 35 Part 6

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Compared to the difficulties Xu Qingzhu encountered in the workplace, Liang Shi's side was relatively smooth sailing.

Only when she came to work did she learn that little Rainbow had finished her reflection time at home and had gone to kindergarten for classes.

After she arrived, Li Ran even asked her if she had seen last night's trending topic.

Liang Shi had drunk too much at the time and had no impression of it, so Li Ran pulled up the video for her and praised her with genuine emotion: "Your acting is really amazing. It's just that whoever started the trending topic doesn't know how to speak properly for the sake of traffic."

Liang Shi first appeared very calm in front of everyone, just smiling lightly: "Not bad. Let's get to work."

But after everyone dispersed, she watched the related clips on Weibo¹ several times.

However, this trending topic had already been taken down, and the discussion level had also decreased.

But Liang Shi was mainly appreciating her own acting skills.

Just as Li Ran went to get hot water, she discovered Liang Shi secretly watching her own performance video. She suddenly made a "hey" sound from behind, startling Liang Shi.

Li Ran laughed: "What are you doing? Admiring your own stunning beauty by yourself?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She embarrassedly put away her phone and smiled awkwardly: "I was just checking where I still need improvement."

Li Ran chuckled: "I understand, I understand."

Liang Shi felt embarrassed by what she said.

Because of that video, everyone's impression of her had improved considerably.

Plus, Zhou Li had completely included her in the category of official employees. During the group meeting on Monday morning, she even took out Liang Shi's work and criticized it thoroughly - the same treatment as other team members. Liang Shi accepted it well and said very sincerely to Zhou Li: "Thank you, Sister Li. I'll work hard."

This attitude was really like an intern's.

So gradually, everyone started calling her "Little Liang."

She was quite happy to respond to it.

Integrating into a new group was simple - just lower your stance and make yourself the same as them.

Liang Shi didn't put on airs either. At noon, she even specially bought drinks for everyone. The magazine department colleagues were immediately won over, calling her "Little Liang" with great affection.

People who had seen her video also asked her: "Why don't you develop in the entertainment industry? With your face and figure, you'd definitely be more popular than Chen Liuying."

One colleague who was an anti-fan of Chen Liuying immediately retorted: "Can you not compare that waste Chen Liuying with our Little Liang? What is our Little Liang? A beautiful and kind-hearted fairy! She doesn't deserve it, she doesn't deserve it!"

Everyone laughed heartily.

At the time, Liang Shi brushed off this topic perfunctorily, and no one mentioned it again.

Liang Shi, who had integrated into the new group, had her own work to do and many new things to learn. She didn't feel the passage of time at all, and before she knew it, it was time to get off work.

Now without a new supervisor, they could leave work on time every day after finishing their own tasks.

Especially the editorial department, because Zhou Li had children at home.

Everyone left the company promptly at six o'clock, saying they refused ineffective overtime and refused workplace involution².

Liang Shi took this principle to the extreme as well.

But after returning home, she had nothing to do, so she just looped the video segment that had been trending last night seven or eight times.

Although the video contained the annoying Chen Liuying, it didn't affect her viewing.

After all, all the comments were praising her.

Footnotes:

1. **Weibo (微博)**: China's equivalent of Twitter, a major social media platform for microblogging.
2. **Workplace involution (職場內卷)**: A modern Chinese term referring to the phenomenon of increasingly intense competition and overwork in professional environments, where people work longer hours without proportional benefits.

Chapter 35 Part 7

Liang Shi had egg pancakes and rice porridge for dinner.

It had been almost three hours since she finished eating, and Xu Qingzhu still hadn't returned home. To the messages she sent, Xu Qingzhu only replied with two words: "Busy."

The more Liang Shi spent time with Xu Qingzhu, the more she realized that some people's success wasn't without reason.

Just with this drive alone, she felt that Xu Qingzhu becoming CEO of a listed company was just a matter of time.

And what she could do was just prepare meals and wait for her to come home.

Because her luck points hadn't reached forty yet, Liang Shi had once sadly asked the system: "Why are luck points so hard to accumulate?"

And the system told her: "Host, you need to work harder! The host next door to me has already had a baby, and you're still here waiting for rabbits by the tree¹."

Liang Shi: "..."

"If I forced her to have a baby, your bad luck point system would kill me." Liang Shi retorted expressionlessly.

The system was sad: "I'm going to be emo. You need to be more proactive."

Liang Shi: "Then you need to tell me how to be proactive."

System: "...I'm just an AI, host."

Liang Shi was silent for a few seconds, then said gloomily: "I'm still a lifelong single²."

System: "..."

BGM suddenly started playing in her mind - "Why don't you just delete me? I can only say this through gritted teeth."

Liang Shi covered her ears: "Shut up."

The system couldn't help but give her advice: "I just went to flip through some romance novels. They're all pinning the female lead against corners saying - 'Is giving you my life enough?'"

Liang Shi held her forehead: "You should just shut up."

Liang Shi felt it would be better to delete this system.

But after finishing her conversation with the system, she looked at the time. She had been in this book for twenty days now, which rounded up was a month.

She still hadn't completed half of her luck point accumulation.

This road was truly long and arduous.

To be honest, the first half of her life had indeed been quite laid-back³, and this temperament hadn't changed much even here.

She only felt a bit of urgency when she first learned she only had three months, but afterward that urgency completely disappeared.

Mainly because no one gave her a clear target, and she spent half the time in the hospital.

It was just... confusion.

During the time Liang Shi spent waiting for Xu Qingzhu to return home that day, she made three plans, divided into Plan A, Plan B, and Plan C.

A: Continue being laid-back, slowly doing tasks.

B: Start sending flowers and gifts, picking up and dropping off from work, frequently creating contact with Xu Qingzhu.

C: Create bonds with Xu Qingzhu - have a baby.

She immediately ruled out both A and C, and B didn't really need consideration either.

She couldn't become a stumbling block on Xu Qingzhu's path to success. If someone suddenly appeared when she was desperately trying to act and prove herself, bringing flowers every day, inviting her to meals, and crazily taking up her time, she would want to hammer that person to death. Forget about liking them - it would be good if she didn't hate them.

As for Plan C, Liang Shi felt it was too despicable, not what a gentleman would do.

Plan A seemed most suitable for her, but... if she continued being so laid-back, she was afraid she might really lose her life someday.

Based on her speculation, the time when she could discuss divorce with Xu Qingzhu would definitely be after the original personality disappeared.

That meant waiting until her luck points accumulated to 80 or 100.

Previously, she had wanted to gain Xu Qingzhu's favor by investigating her parents' affairs. Since Xu Qingzhu was now so busy her feet barely touched the ground, all Liang Shi could do was approach from the side, trying to gain favorability without disturbing her work. But with the investigation interrupted, she was stuck in a bottleneck again.

Every day she thought about cooking for Xu Qingzhu, but that person was too busy to even come home.

Liang Shi was sitting on the sofa holding a book and thinking when Xu Qingzhu returned.

She had just walked over when she saw Liang Shi reading a book, but her book was upside down.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"What are you reading?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

This sound brought Liang Shi's wandering thoughts back, and she answered without thinking:
"Reading a book."

Xu Qingzhu looked meaningfully at the book in her hands, her eyes saying - Do you think I believe you?

Liang Shi looked down and discovered her book was indeed upside down.

...

She immediately flipped the book right-side up, but didn't continue reading. She just closed the book and stood up to ask: "Have you eaten?"

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Does eating a piece of bread count?"

"You only had a piece of bread for dinner?" Liang Shi frowned. "How can bread count as a meal..."

Before she could finish her denial, Xu Qingzhu said: "I only ate a piece of bread all day."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her steps toward the kitchen stopped, and she turned back to look at her. She found Xu Qingzhu extremely exhausted, already curled up where she had just been sitting, casually grabbing a cushion to put under her head. Her long hair was scattered at her sides, and two buttons of her white shirt were undone, revealing a large expanse of her collarbone area, which was soon completely covered by her falling hair.

Seeing this, Liang Shi's heart softened, feeling quite empathetic.

In the past, when she was too tired from filming and came back, she was in this same state. An emotionally draining scene might require twenty-some takes due to her co-actor's mistakes, and each time she needed the same explosive power. She would be completely drained.

After returning, she just wanted to curl up alone and didn't want anyone to talk to her.

But Liang Shi still couldn't help muttering quietly: "Do you really think you're made of iron?"

Xu Qingzhu heard this and laughed lightly, her voice also low: "Do you think I can't hear you?"

There were only the two of them at home, with no other sounds.

They could hear each other's voices clearly.

Liang Shi didn't argue: "I was saying it for you to hear. If you exhaust your body now, what will you do later? There's still time before the new product launch."

Xu Qingzhu rubbed her ears: "I know. You're like an old nanny."

Liang Shi: "..."

She poked her head out from the kitchen doorway: "Just consider me nosy."

But in less than two minutes, she brought out a bowl of steaming white porridge for Xu Qingzhu: "Get up and drink a bowl of porridge first to fill your stomach. I'll go heat up other things for you."

Xu Qingzhu reluctantly sat up and reached for the bowl with both hands, but burned her fingers.

Liang Shi immediately put the bowl aside and half-knelt in front of the sofa to blow on her fingers, frowning: "How can you be so reckless? It just came out of the microwave."

"I thought you wanted me to hold it." Xu Qingzhu spoke weakly but still argued with her: "Who knew it would be so hot?"

Liang Shi blew on her fingers, which were still red: "I'll get you some ointment."

"It's nothing serious, no need." Xu Qingzhu said: "It didn't even blister. I'm not that delicate."

Liang Shi looked again and still got up, but was pulled back by Xu Qingzhu from behind: "I said no need. I just want to eat."

"Alright." Liang Shi said: "I was just telling you to use the spoon in the bowl to scoop it directly."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She looked up: "Didn't you say you were going to heat up other things?"

"I can do that after you finish eating." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She silently picked up the spoon.

Xu Qingzhu ate quite quickly. She seemed truly hungry, eating spoonful after spoonful, and quickly finished the bowl.

Liang Shi asked her: "Do you want more?"

She shook her head.

"I'll make you a dish." Liang Shi said: "Five minutes, okay?"

Xu Qingzhu paused: "Liang Shi, I want to eat noodles."

"What kind of noodles?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu answered without thinking: "Boiled noodles."

1. **"Waiting for rabbits by the tree" (守株待兔)**: A Chinese idiom about a farmer who saw a rabbit accidentally run into a tree and die, then spent his time waiting by the tree for more rabbits instead of working. It refers to waiting passively for good fortune instead of taking action.
2. **"Lifelong single" (母胎SOLO)**: Internet slang meaning someone who has been single since birth and has never been in a romantic relationship.
3. **"Laid-back" (佛系)**: Modern Chinese slang meaning to have a detached, easygoing attitude toward life, derived from Buddhist philosophy of non-attachment.

Chapter 35 Part 8

...

The air froze in an instant.

Originally, when Xu Qingzhu said this sentence, she had no improper thoughts at all, but when Liang Shi's expression changed, she suddenly realized something was a bit off.

Xu Qingzhu patted her forehead and explained: "I mean just regular boiled noodles."

Liang Shi: "..."

She coughed lightly: "I understand."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Do you really understand?

Liang Shi: "..."

She should.

//

Liang Shi made meat sauce noodles¹ for Xu Qingzhu, which took about eight minutes to finish.

Xu Qingzhu had also rested enough on the sofa and got up to eat at the dining table.

A bowl of steaming hot noodles, with wisps of vapor dispersing in the air, brought a warm, homey atmosphere to the somewhat cold house.

After eating a few bites of noodles, Xu Qingzhu asked: "What did you have for dinner?"

"Rice porridge and egg pancakes." Liang Shi asked: "Do you want some egg pancakes? I also made some pickled vegetables in the fridge."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Why don't I have a little?"

Before eating, Xu Qingzhu hadn't felt hungry at all.

She had been working non-stop at the company just to solve the Zhou Yi'an design draft problem.

In the end, it was finally resolved.

She couldn't put in so much effort only to let Sally, who had come from so far away to help, and Lin Luoxi, who had put aside her personal studio, suffer grievances. Having them come to help was already something to be extremely grateful for. If Zhou Yi'an had pushed them out of the flagship position, she really could have jumped in the river.

This whole day had been filled with grievances and anger, yet she had to constantly suppress her emotions. Xu Qingzhu didn't feel hungry at all - she was practically full from anger alone.

But after drinking that bowl of rice porridge from Liang Shi, she suddenly felt like she could eat a whole cow.

So she not only finished a large bowl of noodles, but also ate a small plate of egg pancakes and half a small jar of Liang Shi's pickled vegetables.

Individually, none of it seemed like much, but together it was twice her usual meal portion.

Liang Shi was quite shocked and worried she might get a stomachache, so before going to the kitchen to wash dishes, she brought her a bottle of digestive yogurt.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She couldn't tell if this would make her more stuffed or hungrier.

She curled up on the sofa, sipping the yogurt in small sips. After Liang Shi came out, she told her: "Zhou Yi'an came to our company."

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi nearly dropped her phone in shock and immediately asked: "Did she go to your company to cause trouble?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu was amused by her thought process. "She's a person with status after all. How could she do such a thing? She joined our company's design department."

"So she's under you?" Liang Shi frowned. "Can you manage her?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Actually, it would be quite difficult.

But hearing this made Xu Qingzhu unhappy. She pressed her temples: "If she joins our company and becomes my subordinate, how can I not manage her?"

Although Liang Shi felt she was talking big, she was too embarrassed to call her out, so she said perfunctorily: "You're right. You can give her a good lesson."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She raised an eyebrow with some provocation: "Are you feeling sorry for her?"

Liang Shi: "?"

Her pupils dilated in shock: "What are you joking about? I'm not crazy."

Liang Shi immediately proved her innocence: "I have nothing to do with her. I'm like a small cake, and bees smell the sweetness and come over - I can't help that."

Xu Qingzhu had been holding back her laughter but couldn't suppress it anymore: "I didn't realize you were quite narcissistic."

Liang Shi: "...This is clear self-awareness."

However, Liang Shi felt she was too tired and didn't want to take up her time. She walked over and patted her shoulder: "Go upstairs to wash up and sleep. Get some rest early. I'll drive you to the company tomorrow morning."

Xu Qingzhu looked up at her. Her cheeks were flushed red on both sides, and her eyes carried some haziness. Liang Shi felt something was wrong and was about to reach out to feel her forehead when she heard Xu Qingzhu say: "Come here, let me hug you."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Did you drink?" Liang Shi used her nose to sniff but didn't smell any alcohol.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "No, I just drank yogurt."

Liang Shi: "..."

Could yogurt make you drunk too?

"Go upstairs and wash up." Liang Shi treated it as nonsense, but before she could leave, she was suddenly pulled by Xu Qingzhu and fell directly onto the sofa, landing right on top of Xu Qingzhu.

That soft body was burning hot, making her heart race as well.

"I said let me hug you." Xu Qingzhu mumbled: "Why won't you listen?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Her forehead fell down, landing right against Xu Qingzhu's forehead.

Hmm, overworked to the point of fever.

Footnotes:

1. **Meat sauce noodles (肉臊子面)**: A traditional Chinese noodle dish with ground meat sauce, similar to bolognese but with Chinese seasonings and preparation methods.